

Feature Writing

District Meet • 2026



You are a reporter for the **Leaguetown Press**, the student newspaper of Leaguetown High School.

From the given information, write a **feature story** as you would for the high school newspaper. You may use statements attributed to individuals as **direct or indirect quotes**. You may not change the meaning of a statement. You have **one hour**.

Do not write your name or the name of your school on this sheet or your entry. **Put your number on your paper.**

Leaguetown High School has 2,894 students in grades 9-12. English teacher Grace Baram's fourth-period class typically stays in her classroom to eat instead of going to the cafeteria for lunch since fourth period is split in half with lunch in the middle. One day in the fall, one student gave senior Gaby Laird a can of sardines from his lunch. Gaby had never tasted sardines, so she decided to film herself tasting the sardine and posted it on her Instagram account. Her video had 500,000 views and 80,000 likes by the end of the week.

The next week, another student brought a small brick of blue cheese for Gaby to try. After posting another video, which received a lot of attention, the class decided to work together to make lunch videos three times a week. Students brought supplies, including a ring light, microphones and tripods. They purchased editing software. After months of creating videos, the group has garnered more than a million followers and has started to earn money from the videos they create. They also started an Influencer Club, which meets after school on Thursdays, in addition to their regular lunch every day during fourth period.

On Thursday, March 26, they will host a guest speaker from BeGood Digital Marketing who will teach students about branding and how to maximize the money earned from social media partnerships. More than 150 students signed up to attend. You are writing for the issue of the Press to be distributed March 24.

■ GABY LAIRD, senior

"A group of us has had lunch in Ms. Baram's classroom every day this year. Her classroom is a calm and peaceful place for us to eat. Once we started eating in there, everyone else in the class started joining, and we'd all talk to each other. I'm a nosy person, and I like to know what people have for lunch. It's like an insight into who they really are. One day I went around asking, 'What are you having for lunch?' and Paul pulled out a can of fish. I had never heard of anyone bringing sardines for lunch. Paul went to Spain this summer, and his mom hid the sardines in his lunch, almost as a joke.

"Paul said he tried them in Spain, and they were actually really good. I thought it was funny that he had this can of fish, so I opened Instagram. I know we aren't supposed to have phones in class, but it was lunch. I began filming myself talking about how Paul brought sardines for lunch. Paul opened the can and put it up to the camera, so the audience could get a close-up of the fish. I smelled it and described it for the camera as almost a lemony, briny smell. Then I popped one in my mouth. By that time, the rest of the class had gathered around the background of the video, and they just started rolling. You can see in the video how my face puckered up when I

■ GABY LAIRD, continued

tasted it. It wasn't as bad as I thought it would be. At the end of the video, I thought it would be funny to reach over to the can and pop another sardine in my mouth right before the video ended. I didn't have that many followers on the app before this. I hate to say we went viral because I'm not sure how to measure when something goes viral. But people seemed to like it. We laughed so hard when we were making that video. We all looked at each other and thought, 'We need to do this again.'

"I renamed the account 'What's for Lunch?' The videos don't take long to make, and nothing is scripted. We let whatever naturally happens be in the video. It's not always me. Anyone can do the tasting, but I'm always the host. We'll learn about what the food is and where it comes from. Then someone gets to taste it. Our rule is that if you bring a food, it has to be something you like. We don't want to eat anything super gross. Now we're making a little bit of money, which we split among the whole class. Someone even recognized me from the videos when I went to a museum the other day. Call it going viral. Call it getting famous. Call it whatever you want. I call it me having fun with my friends in my English class. It's some of the most fun I've ever had, and I wish we could keep it going forever."

■ GRACE BARAM, English teacher

"I have always loved having students eat lunch with me in my classroom. I don't know what it is about this fourth-period class, but all 22 of them have stayed in my room for lunch since the third week of school. I know this is a tight-knit group of seniors. That's probably a big part of it, but a lot of it has to do with Gaby. Her leadership makes everyone feel included and want to be a part of whatever she has going on. Every day, she talks to each person in the class, just to make them feel special. Lunch is our 25-minute break from class every day just to laugh and enjoy each other.

"It's been a blast watching their social media project evolve the way it has. I've brought German chocolate cake and homemade butter for them to taste. We've had students and parents bring homemade dishes. One girl even brought homemade pickle cupcakes that were weirdly good. It's wild to see this little joke they had take on a new life. This is an extra special group of seniors for me. I can't wait to see how they use their special powers in the future."

■ PAUL RHOADES, senior

"Every day when we're through with the lunch period, my side hurts from laughing so hard. I'll never forget the first time we made a video with the sardines. I like that the videos are kind and encouraging. They aren't making fun of anyone. They aren't even making fun of the food we're eating. We're just eating foods you don't see every day and showing people what they're like.

"I think I could do social media for my career. Once we got all the equipment we needed, I took on a lot of the production responsibilities. I do the editing on my phone and add music. I'm excited for the speaker to come in and talk about social media as a career a little more. They talk about these types of careers in our classes or in the counseling office. I'm looking at this as another opportunity for me to learn and grow our brand."

■ TIM SYKES, BeGood Digital Marketing

"I've been following the 'What's for Lunch?' account for a few months now. These kids have some powerful instincts in terms of what audiences want to see and how to engage with different groups. There's just something so appealing about them. I'm anxious to talk to the next generation about the industry and how it's changed. There's a whole world of new careers out there that most people don't even think about."

DO NOT DISTRIBUTE TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST!

District Meet • 2026 Feature Writing Contest Tips and Sample Story

Contest Director: Give one copy to each judge to use during critiquing/judging. Also, staple one copy of the contest and one copy of the contest tips to each student's returned entry. The purpose of the tips is to provide immediate feedback to students. However, it is not meant to replace written comments from the judge.

1. Figure out what the story is about and its theme or focus. This story is about a group of students who started an Influencer Club after going viral on social media.

2. The lead of a feature story must grab the reader's attention. It does not have to be a certain length or include the 5Ws and H. It should set a scene and get the reader into the story. Although you have freedom to describe the scene as you think it might have existed, try to stay close to the prompt. Judges will not want you to wander off the subject too much.

When senior Gaby Laird popped that first sardine into her mouth, she didn't expect it to change her life. But she filmed her reaction and the video went viral on social media. Now, English teacher Grace Baram's fourth-period class has started its own Influencer Club.

3. Once you get past the lead, make sure you include a nut graph. It tells the reader what the story will be about. Follow the nut graph with a direct quote and then go into the transition/quote formula. In this story, the news peg is in the lead, but additional information is required.

nut graph

An industry expert from BeGood Digital Marketing will speak to the club and more than 150 other students about careers in social media after school Thursday in the auditorium.

direct quote

"Call it going viral," Gaby said. "Call it getting famous. Call it whatever you want. I call it me having fun with my friends in my English class."

4. After the nut graph, the rest of the story can tell itself through the use of transition/quote formula. Be sure you attribute after the quote or at least after the first sentence. An attribution should be: subject of attribution followed by the verb of attribution ("Olsen said" not "said Olsen"). Avoid putting two or more quotes together without placing some kind of transition between them. Also, make sure transitions provide information to help the action of the story and that the quote does not repeat information in the transition.

transition/story-telling

Having lunch in Baram's classroom, the group created its first video when Gaby asked each person what they were having for lunch. Senior Paul Rhoades pulled

out a can of sardines.

direct quote

“I had never heard of anyone bringing sardines for lunch,” Gaby said. “Paul said he tried them in Spain and they were actually really good. I just thought it was funny that he had this can of fish, so I opened Instagram.”

5. Always use third person. Don’t say “your students” or “our students.” Also, do not editorialize. For instance, you should not say “Go Gaby!” These statements are personal opinions and should not be used in a feature story.

6. Always use the verb “said” as the verb of attribution. Don’t say “says,” “stated,” “feels” or any other synonym for “said.”

7. Finally, look for a strong quote to use as a closing statement or a statement that will bring the reader back to the beginning of the story. It should give the reader a sense of satisfaction or resolution.

Paul said he is looking forward to hearing marketing expert Tim Sykes speak to students as they continue to grow their club and brand. In fact, Sykes has been following the students’ work on their “What’s for Lunch?” account.

“These kids have some powerful instincts in terms of what audiences want to see and how to engage with different groups,” he said. “There’s just something so appealing about them.”

SAMPLE STORY

When senior Gaby Laird popped that first sardine into her mouth, she didn't expect it to change her life. But she filmed her reaction and the video went viral on social media. Now, English teacher Grace Baram's fourth-period class has started its own Influencer Club.

An industry expert from BeGood Digital Marketing will speak to the club and more than 150 other students about careers in social media after school Thursday in the auditorium.

"Call it going viral," Gaby said. "Call it getting famous. Call it whatever you want. I call it me having fun with my friends in my English class."

Having lunch in Baram's classroom, the group created its first video when Gaby asked each person what they were having for lunch. Senior Paul Rhoades pulled out a can of sardines.

"I had never heard of anyone bringing sardines for lunch," Gaby said. "Paul said he tried them in Spain and they were actually really good. I just thought it was funny that he had this can of fish, so I opened Instagram."

That first video of Gaby trying a sardine had 500,000 views and 80,000 likes by the end of the week.

"Paul opened the can and put it up to the camera so the audience could get a close-up of the fish," she said. "I smelled it and described it for the camera as almost a lemony, briny smell. Then I popped one in my mouth."

By that time, the whole class had gathered in the background of the video to share the reaction to the sardine tasting.

"People seemed to like it," Gaby said. "We laughed so hard when we were making that video. We all looked at each other and thought, 'We need to do this again.'"

Gaby eventually renamed her account "What's for Lunch?" as the group began bringing in unique foods to taste and taking turns being the taster with Gaby as the host. Since then, the group has earned more than a million followers and began making money for the videos they produce, which they share equally among the class.

"It's been a blast watching their social media project evolve the way it has," Baram said. "It's wild to see the this little joke they had take on a new life. This is an extra special group of seniors for me. I can't wait to see how they use their special powers in the future."

Paul, still a fan of sardines, has taken on the role of producer, managing equipment and helping manage the account.

"Every day when we're through with the lunch period, my side hurts from laughing so hard," he said. "I like that the videos are kind and encouraging. We're just eating foods you don't see every day and showing people what they're like."

Paul, who plans to do social media for his career, said he is looking forward to hearing marketing expert Tim Sykes speak to students as they continue to grow their club and brand. In fact, Sykes has been following the students' work on their "What's for Lunch?" account.

"These kids have some powerful instincts in terms of what audiences want to see and how to engage with different groups," he said. "There's just something so appealing about them."